

grammatical authority codifying social and economic events; but try to convince a bureaucrat or social scientist that the world might not want to follow his “scientific” equations. In fact, thinkers of the Austrian school, to which Hayek belonged, used the designations *tacit* or *implicit* precisely for that part of knowledge that cannot be written down, but that we should avoid repressing. They made the distinction we saw earlier between “know-how” and “know-what”—the latter being more elusive and more prone to nerdification.

To clarify, Platonic is top-down, formulaic, closed-minded, self-serving, and commoditized; a-Platonic is bottom-up, open-minded, skeptical, and empirical.

The reason for my singling out the great Plato becomes apparent with the following example of the master’s thinking: Plato believed that we should use both hands with equal dexterity. It would not “make sense” otherwise. He considered favoring one limb over the other a deformation caused by the “folly of mothers and nurses.” Asymmetry bothered him, and he projected his ideas of elegance onto reality. We had to wait until Louis Pasteur to figure out that chemical molecules were either left- or right-handed and that this mattered considerably.

One can find similar ideas among several disconnected branches of thinking. The earliest were (as usual) the empirics, whose bottom-up, theory-free, “evidence-based” medical approach was mostly associated with Philnus of Cos, Serapion of Alexandria, and Glaucias of Tarentum, later made skeptical by Menodotus of Nicomedia, and currently well-known by its vocal practitioner, our friend the great skeptical philosopher Sextus Empiricus. Sextus who, we saw earlier, was perhaps the first to discuss the Black Swan. The empirics practiced the “medical art” without relying on reasoning; they wanted to benefit from chance observations by making guesses, and experimented and tinkered until they found something that worked. They did minimal theorizing.

Their methods are being revived today as evidence-based medicine, after two millennia of persuasion. Consider that before we knew of bacteria, and their role in diseases, doctors rejected the practice of hand washing because it *made no sense* to them, despite the evidence of a meaningful decrease in hospital deaths. Ignaz Semmelweis, the mid-nineteenth-century doctor who promoted the idea of hand washing, wasn’t vindicated until decades after his death. Similarly it may not “make sense” that acupuncture works, but if pushing a needle in someone’s toe systematically produces relief from pain (in properly conducted empirical tests), then it could be that there are functions too complicated for us to understand, so let’s go with it for now while keeping our minds open.